HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Why It's Never Enough: Histapkut & the Secret of Real Wealth

Given Monday 7 September 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem 9

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Rabbeinu Avraham ben HaRambam) — Rav Dana's Hebrew edition

Chapter: Perek Tet (9) — **Histapkut**, contentment / self-sufficiency

Topic: The meaning and root of *histapkut*; how one trains for it; its relationship to bitachon (Ch 8) and perishut (Ch 10); the Torah's own testimony to the trait; the spiritual damage caused by its absence; and the practice of the prophets in receiving gifts

Schedule note: First shiur back after the summer break, a few days before Rosh Hashanah. Normally each new term opens with a summary of everything learned so far — but the calendar makes that impractical now: **next Monday is Tzom Gedaliah** (no shiur, because of Minchah/Maariv), then **Yom Kippur**, then **Chol HaMoed Sukkot**, then **Asru Chag**. So Chapter 9 — short and self-contained — is being learned in full tonight, and **HaMaspik then breaks until after Sukkot**. On return: a **full recap of Chapters 1–9**, then **Chapter 10 — Perishut (abstinence)**, and the sefer should be finished comfortably **before Pesach**, probably earlier.

New feature from after Sukkot: aside from HaMaspik, Rabbeinu Avraham also wrote a **commentary on the Torah** — he wrote on all five books as far as we know, but only **Bereishit and Shemot** survive. Each week the **last 5–10 minutes** of the shiur will be given to a selected piece of his commentary on the weekly parashah, which will carry us through Bereishit and Shemot from after Sukkot until Pesach. (Shiur time may shift slightly in October until the clocks change — watch the group.)

Recap — Where We Are

Chapter	Trait
Earlier chapters	The path of Hashem: purity of action, humility, and the other middot covered in the first part of the sefer
8	**Bitachon** — reliance and trust in Hashem. A long chapter with many parts, completed at the end of the summer term
9 (tonight)	**Histapkut** — contentment
10 (next)	**Perishut** — abstinence

Part One — What Does *Histapkut* Mean?

The Root ס־פ־ק

The **tav** in *histapkut* is only the *hitpa'el* (reflexive) form; the root is **ספק** — samech, peh, kuf. The Rabbi raised a genuine open question here: **what does this root actually mean in Tanach?** He researched it and could not resolve it, and invites anyone who has seen an answer to share it. There are **three distinct connotations**, and he could not find the link between them:

1. To clap / to strike

ויחר אף בלק אל בלעם ויספק את כפיו

After Balak's three failed attempts to have Bilam curse, he **clapped his hands**. (A participant noted that in **Arabic** the root likewise means to clap — the Rabbi: "exactly, very good.")

Note: פוסחים על שתי הסעפים is a different root entirely — that is a se'if, not a safek.

2. To provide / to supply what suffices

Lesapek — to provide for someone: **סיפק לו את צרכיו**, **סיפק להם את המן**. Common in rabbinic literature. **Why does providing come from this root?** Because when you provide for someone, **you give them what is sufficient for them**. This is the sense we are using tonight: **to suffice, to be enough**.

3. Doubt — *safek*. The Rabbi's sense is that this is the **latest** of the three usages.

Ordinarily, when a Hebrew root carries several connotations, thinking properly will reveal a connection between them. **Here the Rabbi could not find one** — clapping, sufficing, and doubt. Worth thinking about.

Flora's question: in modern Hebrew we say *lo hispakti* — "I didn't manage to." Is that the same word? **Yes** — the same idea: I was not sufficient, I did not have enough. **Sufficient and content are the same word.** (And no, it is not from *doubt* — that is the separate third connotation.)

So **histapkut** is a reflexive noun from the second sense: **I am self-sufficient, I am self-content, I have everything I need.**

Part Two — The Definition (Rabbeinu Avraham's Opening)

הסתפקות מן המידות התרומיות

Contentment is among the exalted character traits.

ופירושה: שיהא אדם שמח בחלקו מקנייני עולם הזה, ולא יהא בהול ורודף להוסיף עליהם

A person is happy with his portion of this world's possessions, and is not frantically chasing after more and more.

והיא מעידה על העדר חמדנות ומיעוט החיבה לתענוגי העולם הזה, המביאה את האדם לידי עבירות ועוולות ופוגעת בהשגת השלמות

The trait **testifies** to the absence of covetousness and to only a slight attachment to the pleasures of this world — an attachment which otherwise leads a person into **sins and injustices** and **damages the pursuit of perfection** (*shelemut*).

והלא יודע אתה כמה הדגישה התורה את איסור החמדנות והתאווה במקרא עשרת הדיברות

Look how strongly the Torah stressed the prohibition of covetousness and desire **in the Ten Commandments** themselves — *lo tachmod*.

ואין דבר המביא לידי חמדנות ותאווה כמו אי הסתפקות — וזללנות ורעבתנות וחמדת עולם הזה וקנאה

And **nothing brings a person to covetousness and desire like the absence of contentment** — gluttony, ravenousness, craving for this world, and jealousy.

In short: when you have this trait, you desire less overall, and in particular you stop desiring **other people's property and possessions**.

The Core of the Trait

ועיקר הסתפקות הוא שלא תהא הנפש תלויה בתענוגות העולם, ולא תשאף אלא לדבר שהוא בגדר ההכרח

The essence: the soul is **not dependent** on the world's pleasures, and **aspires only to what falls within the category of necessity**.

I aspire to a home to live in. I aspire to food and drink, and not to worry where the next meal comes from. I aspire to provide for my children's needs. **That is what contentment aspires to.**

How You Train For It

וההכשרה המביאה לידי הסתפקות: הכשרת הנפש והרגלתה להסתפק בדברים שהם בהכרח ולהתרחק מן המותרות

The training that produces contentment is **habituating the soul** to suffice with the necessary and to keep away from luxuries.

The Rabbi's illustration: there is nothing wrong with a treat. It is Shabbat or Yom Tov, you want a nice ice cream, you want to order a McFlurry — enjoy, no problem at all. But during an ordinary week, when a person trains himself to say **"I don't need this. There is nothing special about today that requires this ice cream — so I won't have it"** — *that* is the training. **Why take more when I already have what I need?** (This develops much further in Chapter 10, perishut.)

וממעט בתקוות השוא ולא ישתדל בהם

And it reduces vain hopes and the effort spent on them — freeing a person for productive and spiritual development.

There Is No Satiety in Physical Things

וכבר אמר שלמה המלך: אוהב כסף לא ישבע כסף

One who loves money is never sated by money.

This is simply the **nature of physical things**: having something makes you want more of it. There is no such thing as being complete in the material. *(The Rambam treats this in the Moreh as well — and we will meet it in **Chapter 17**, next week's Moreh chapter.)*

והרי זו דוגמה לשאר דברים — this is only an **example**; it is not specifically about money.

If you love ice cream you will never be satisfied by it either. Yes, you may eat so much that you feel ill and want no more — but a few hours later, tomorrow, you want more. **Whatever it is in life, you will always want more.**

והוא דבר שאין לו קצבה — it has no limit, **כמו שנאמר: לא תשבע עין לראות ולא תמלא אזן משמע**.

:Rabbeinu Avraham quotes **his father, the Rambam** (in the Moreh, section three) — **אמר אבא מורי**

If you feel you must have **silver** vessels — remember there are finer **gold** ones. And if you aspire to gold — think of those who have **crystal**.

וכל בר דעת יעריך אפוא את מידת ההסתפקות, כי היא עושרו האמיתי

Any sensible person will therefore value contentment — **because it is his true wealth**.

Which brings to mind exactly what everyone is thinking of — the Mishnah in Pirkei Avot:

איזהו עשיר? השמח בחלקו

That is true *ashirut*. And this is the Rabbi's point about material things: you may be temporarily satisfied, but the reality is you will want more. Think of the well-known studies of **lottery winners** — within a very short time, weeks or at best months, they return to their original baseline of happiness. Yes, life may be more convenient and the financial worries lighter — but in terms of *happiness*, nothing has moved.

Q&A — Olivia: Wanting Something for a Child

Olivia asked: if a person is content for himself but **wishes something for his child** — for example, that the child should get married — is that a failure of contentment? It isn't a material thing; for a man it is a mitzvah from the Torah, and for a woman too there is a mitzvah.

The Rabbi's answer — and he noted it revealed the progression of the chapters beautifully:

Forget the child for a moment; take yourself. *I am not married and I want to get married.* **That is not a lack of histapkut** — because I know it is the right thing in life for me. The Torah says clearly **לא טוב היות האדם לבדו**; I know what the Chachamim say, I know the halachah, I know the mitzvah. **You cannot say "I'll be content and stay unmarried" — that is wrong.** Like every character trait, contentment applied in the wrong place is a fault, not a virtue.

So how do the two chapters divide?

Domain	Which trait applies
Material matters — money, food, a house, possessions	**Chapter 9 — Histapkut.** I have what Hashem has given me; I am content.
Non-material, obligatory matters — mitzvot, Torah values, marriage	**Want it, desire it, pursue it.** That is not a lack of contentment. And if you do not have it yet — **Chapter 8, Bitachon.** It will come at the right time.

So: I am not married and I am not content about it — should I be depressed? **No: bitachon.** That is exactly how Chapter 8 flows into Chapter 9.

Part Three — Histapkut and Perishut (the Chapter 10 Connection)

וההסתפקות היא יסוד ושורש למידת הפרישות

Contentment is the **foundation and root** of abstinence — that a person minimizes **even from the permitted** (as the whole next chapter explains, including the intent behind *sigufim*).

ומבחינה ידועה נובעת הסתפקות מן הפרישות

And from a certain perspective the arrow runs **the other way**: contentment flows *from* abstinence — **כי מסתפק הוא מי שאינו מצטער ממה שלא השיג מצרכיו, ושמח בחלקו הניתן לו**, since the content person is the one who is not pained by what he did not attain and is happy with the portion given him.

> **נמצא אפוא שהפורש מענייני העולם, מחייבת פרישותו למידת ההסתפקות — וכל בעל פרישות אפוא בעל הסתפקות. אבל לא כל בעל הסתפקות הוא בעל פרישות.**

The rule: everyone who has reached perishut necessarily has histapkut — you could not truly abstain without being content. **But not everyone who is content has reached perishut.**

A worked example: Baruch Hashem, I have a good home, a good family, enough money — I have what I need, and I also partake of things beyond the strictly necessary. You have the means, you enjoy it, there is nothing wrong with it. **You are Chapter 9, but you are not yet Chapter 10.**

Flora's exchange: she raised Rashi on **קדושים תהיו** — that holiness means abstaining *min ha'arayot* — and asked whether holiness and contentment connect: part of feeling holy is feeling whole, feeling that you need nothing else. The Rabbi was not convinced of the link to *histapkut* specifically; and the **Ramban's** famous **נבל ברשות התורה** on that same verse belongs squarely to **Chapter 10 — perishut**, not to this chapter.

Part Four — Histapkut Is One of the Torah's Own Aims

וההסתפקות היא אחת ממטרות התורה

Rabbeinu Avraham brings **three** proofs:

> **1. לא תחמד ולא תתאווה בית רעך** — the Torah's own prohibition on covetousness (Ten Commandments).

2. The qualifications of judges. When **Yitro** advises Moshe on the system of judges he lists seven qualities, among them **שונאי בצע** — haters of unjust gain. Rabbeinu Avraham (in his commentary on the Torah) explains this to mean **not merely that you hate money, but that you have no desire for it at all**. That is a very high level — complete contentment — and the Torah makes it a **qualification for the bench**.

3. Ben Sorer U'Moreh. Consider carefully what the verses say and what Chazal transmitted orally about the rebellious son — a boy stoned, with his own father and mother handing him over and commanded **not to pity him**. What did he do that was so terrible?

> **הוא חטא התאווה, כמו שכתוב: זולל וסבא — וכן תרגם המתרגם: זליל בבישרא וסבי חמרא** — he devours meat and guzzles wine.

ודברים אלו נועדו לבטא זולל וסובא בעצמו, כמו שנאמר: אל תהי בסבאי יין בזוללי בשר למו

Even though the case of *ben sorer u'moreh* also involves **theft of property** and **breaking away from the mussar of the words of God and of halachah**, **its essence is gluttony and drunkenness**, as the Gemara in **Sanhedrin** has it.

The Rabbi's explanation: the Gemara stacks up so many conditions — he must have stolen from his parents' money, used it to buy meat and wine, consumed them within a very short window, his parents must not be disabled, and (per one opinion) must have identical voices — that the case becomes practically impossible; one opinion holds **it never happened and never will**. **That is not the point.** The point is **the value the parashah teaches**: the root is *zolel v'sovei* — **an indulgent person, never content, always wanting more.**

Part Five — The Damage Done by Its Absence

הוה זהיר אפוא שלא תדבק נפשך בתענוגי העולם... על כן תסתפק בהכרחי ותרגיל עצמך לשבוע בהכרחי, כי תענוגות הללו הן מכשול גדול לדרכך בפרישות

ודע, כי אי ההסתפקות היא הסיבה היותר חזקה להיכשל בעבירות חמורות ולדחות מצוות עשה גדולות

Know that a lack of contentment is the single most powerful cause of falling into serious sins and of pushing aside great positive commandments.

This is quite a statement. Why is it so?

Step 1 — Most people never attain what they aspire to

כי מי שמטפח תקוות גדולות בענייני העולם הזה — לא ישיג על פי רוב את תאוותו, ולא יצלח בידו הרבה ממה שהוא מתאווה לו

"I want to make X amount, I want that kind of house, that kind of car." It is a fact of life that **the majority do not attain** the material goals they set out with, **כמו שאמרו חכמינו: אוהב כסף לא ישבע כסף**.

Step 2 — The first aveirah: bitul Torah

he spends most of his hours and years — **ומתוך כך מוציא רוב עיתותיו ועונותיו להשיג את תקוותיהם** chasing it.

the first transgression is neglect — **עבירה הראשונה שעובר בזה היא ביטול מצווה שהיא עיקר כל המצוות** of the mitzvah that is the **root of them all**: **talmud Torah**.

שהרי אמרו תנאים: כך היא דרכה של תורה — פת במלח תאכל, ומים במשורה תשתה, ועל הארץ תישן, וחיי צער תחיה, ובתורה אתה עמל

The Rabbi's crucial qualification: a person **must** work to earn and provide, and if the job genuinely requires those hours, **that is fine — that is the will of Hashem**. The problem is the hours worked **beyond** what parnasah requires, purely to have the most beautiful house in the community, the most money, the best car. **Those extra hours are bitul Torah.** And this explains the Mishnah: it is not a glorification of poverty but a statement of what acquiring Torah requires — **if you constantly want more and better, you will not have the time to acquire Torah at all.**

Step 3 — And if honest means don't get you there

ואם לא השיג התקוות הללו בכשר — כגון שיסע בים וביבשה וממדינה למדינה לקנות סחורה בזול — אז יקנה... מגזל ואבק גזל ושבועת שוא במשא ומתן

First the endless travel — by sea and land, country to country, buying cheap and selling. (The Rabbi's observation: **the wealthier a person is, the more he seems to be on planes.**) And when even that fails to reach the target: **theft, the dust of theft, and false oaths in business.**

Step 4 — And if you *do* attain it

ואם השיג התקוות הללו — ישתעבד בתענוגותיהם ויכנס עוד בתפלות עסקיו של עולם

Now you are **enslaved to the pleasures themselves**. I have the money — now I must use it: parties to throw, the finest materials for the finest house. And so you still cannot learn Torah or do

the mitzvot, because you are consumed with spending what you made.

And that assumes you reach it in time to enjoy it. Most who do reach their aspirations reach them **too late** — the dream home is finally built, and they are already pensioners who can barely walk through it.

Step 5 — Mitzvot hollowed out

הן ביציאת חוץ מן המצווה... הן בביטול תוכה — either you drop the mitzvah entirely, or you **empty it of its content**:

כגון מי שקורא קריאת שמע או מתפלל שחרית במהירות עצומה — Shema or Shacharit raced through;

מתפלל ערבית מתוך שינה, **מתוך כוח המשא ורוב העבודה כל היום** — Arvit prayed half-asleep, from the sheer weight of the day's business;

ויברך בחטיפה ברכת המוציא, שכיוון שגמר ברכתו השיג תאוותו — HaMotzi snatched, because the moment the berachah ends he has what he wanted;

ויחטוף ברכת המזון בעוד לבו ועיניו נרדמים מחמת כרסו המטופחת — Birkat HaMazon grabbed while his heart and eyes are dozing from his stuffed stomach.

On HaMotzi: the berachah is only **ten words** — ברוך אתה ה' אלוקינו מלך העולם המוציא לחם מן הארץ — which is why we place **ten fingers**, both hands, on the bread as we say it. **Not only on Shabbat** — any time you have bread, even a weekday sandwich. This is also why we say **עיני כל אליך ישברו ואתה נותן להם את אכלם בעתו** — likewise ten words.

The Rabbi's story: after a long service — Shabbat, Rosh Chodesh — he was making kiddush slowly, waiting for people to come in and hear it. Someone was so hungry and thirsty that as the Rabbi was still saying **ברוך אתה ה' אלוקינו מלך העולם**, he had already drunk his grape juice. That is exactly the phenomenon Rabbeinu Avraham describes.

עוד נשוב בעזרת השם לעניין הפרישות — more on this in Chapter 10.

Part Six — The Prophets and the Receiving of Gifts

איני סבור שיש צורך לבאר לך דבר הסתפקותם ופרישותם של נביאים, ושל פרושי האומות הקודמות מחסידים ואנשי מעשה, עד שהגיעו לתלמידיהם

It hardly needs saying that the prophets — and the ascetics of earlier nations, the chasidim and anshei ma'aseh, down to their disciples — possessed contentment and abstinence.

But here is the point worth your attention:

אבל עליך לתת דעתך, כי שלילת גאוותם וכן פרישותם והסתפקותם גרמו להם שיקבלו מה שניתן להם מן המתנות דרך של מקבלי נדבה

Their **absence of arrogance**, together with their perishut and histapkut, is precisely what allowed them to **receive gifts** as recipients of a nedavah. **Three reasons:**

וכל זאת מפני חוסר גאוותם — to accept a gift at all, you must not be arrogant.

ומפני ידיעתם כי הניתן להם בא מאיתו יתעלה, והנותן הוא רק מתווך — they recognized that what was given came **from Hashem**, and the giver is merely an **intermediary**. This was their parnasah, sent by Hashem.

וגם מפני שקבלת המתנות תעניק לנותן עונג רב ושפע טובה וברכה — because **receiving gives the giver great pleasure**, and an abundance of good and blessing.

The halachic parallel — adam chashuv: to effect kiddushin a man must give the woman something of value — hence the ring. But if a **woman gives a gift to a genuinely important person** and he accepts it from her, **he can betroth her through that acceptance** — because the pleasure she receives from his accepting her gift is itself the value. That is the halachah of *adam chashuv*. **You see from it that there is real benefit conferred by allowing someone to give to you.** Sometimes the cruellest thing is to refuse: someone truly wants to express gratitude — "please accept this" — and the refusal denies them that.

The Practice Was Standard — Three Proofs

1. Shaul and his attendant, going to Shmuel

והנה נלך, ומה נביא לאיש? כי הלחם אזל מכלינו ותשורה אין להביא לאיש האלוקים — מה אתנו?

And the attendant answers: **הנה נמצא בידי רבע שקל כסף, ונתתי לאיש האלוקים והגיד לנו את דרכנו**.

standard practice: you come to the prophet for — **מכאן ראיה כי כך היו מביאים מנחה לאנשי האלוקים** guidance, you bring a gift.

2. Yeravam sending his wife to Achiyah HaShiloni

Yeravam's son was ill. Yeravam — a sinner, whether embarrassed or too proud — sends his wife, telling her to **disguise herself** and to take:

ולקחת בידך עשרה לחם ונקדים ובקבק דבש ובאת אליו, הוא יגיד לך מה יהיה לנער

Bread, cakes and honey — the gift accompanies the request.

3. The man from Baal Shalishah, to Elisha

ואיש בא מבעל שלשה ויבא לאיש האלוקים לחם בכורים עשרים לחם שערים וכרמל בצקלנו, ויאמר: תן לעם ויאכלו

From this verse the **Gemara in Ketubot** derives that bringing a gift to a **talmid chacham** is like bringing **bikurim**.

*(Rabbeinu Avraham notes that this is one of the practices the **Sufis** — פרושי האסלאם — copied from us: their leaders too would accept gifts from the people.)*

The Two Caveats

Caveat 1 — take only the little, return the much

אבל עליך לדעת שהנביאים היו מקבלים רק את המועט ומחזירים את המרובה

Caveat 2 — only from someone it is fitting to receive from

ולא היו מקבלים אלא ממי שהוא מוכשר וראוי לקבל דבר שבא ממנו

The proof for both: the very same **Elisha** who accepted the twenty barley loaves **returned** Naaman's **ten kikarim of silver and six thousand gold pieces** after his tzara'at was cured, and refused the **forty camel-loads** sent by **Ben Hadad**.

And this explains the disguise: Yeravam told his wife to dress as someone else **בדאגתו כי לו ידע הנביא שהיא אשתו, לא היה עולה על דעתו שיקבל ממנה** — he knew that had Achiyah known whose wife she was, he would never have accepted from her and would not have given the guidance.

ולא יצדק המקבל מתנות מן הפרוצים וכדומיהם באמתלא שצריך להם, ושהוא אוכל מתנות השם — והבן את הדבר כראוי

One cannot justify accepting from the unworthy on the excuse that "I need it" or "I am eating from Hashem's gifts." **Understand this properly.**

The Rabbi's aside: people like to say that **donations come in all currencies** — but the reality is that you accept from the **appropriate** people.

And the Rambam's related ruling: the Torah commands **ולדבקה בו** — to cleave to Hashem. The Gemara asks how this is possible and answers: **cleave to the chachamim** — marry your daughter to a talmid chacham's son, and **do business (perakmatia) with them** — help invest with them. From this the Rambam rules (in his **commentary to Pirkei Avot**, which we learned together a few years ago) that **it is a mitzvah to do business with a chacham**. Outright gifts, by contrast, are only from the right person and only in the necessary amount. **And this fits Rabbeinu Avraham exactly:** since accepting a gift confers a benefit on the giver, it makes sense with someone from whom it is fitting to receive — but why confer that benefit on a rasha?

Summary — Chapter 9

Histapkut is contentment: being happy with one's portion and not frantically chasing more. One **trains** for it by aspiring only to what is necessary and by recognizing that in material things **there is always more** — silver, then gold, then crystal — so that **אוהב כסף לא ישבע כסף** and **איזהו עשיר? השמח בחלקו**. It sits between two chapters: **material** wants belong to histapkut, while **obligatory, mitzvah matters** (marriage and the like) should be desired, with **bitachon** (Ch 8) carrying you until they come. Anyone who has attained **perishut** (Ch 10) necessarily has histapkut, though not the reverse. The Torah itself values the trait — from **לא תחמד**, from **שונאי בצע** as a qualification for judges, and from **ben sorer u'moreh**, whose essence is *zolel v'sovei*. Its absence is **the strongest cause of serious sin and of neglected mitzvot**: most never attain their aspirations, and meanwhile lose Torah to the extra hours, slide toward gezel and false oaths, and — if they do attain — become enslaved to spending it, with mitzvot raced through or hollowed out. Finally, the **prophets** received gifts, out of humility, out of recognition that the giver is only Hashem's intermediary, and because receiving is itself a kindness to the giver — but **only the little, returning the much, and only from those from whom it is fitting to receive**.

Coming Up

- **No shiur next Monday** (Tzom Gedaliah), nor through Yom Kippur, Chol HaMoed Sukkot and Asru Chag. HaMaspik **resumes after Sukkot**.
- On return: a **full recap of Chapters 1–9**, then **Chapter 10 — Perishut (abstinence)**, where *sigufim*, the Ramban's **נבל ברשות התורה**, and the further discussion of the prophets' abstinence all belong. Only a few chapters remain after that; the sefer should be completed **before Pesach**.
- **New weekly feature after Sukkot:** the last 5–10 minutes on a selected piece of **Rabbeinu Avraham's commentary on the parashah** (Bereishit and Shemot), running through the winter until Pesach.
- Shiur time may vary slightly in October until the clocks change — details on the group.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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